

A 'Giant' of a deal in the works

By J. FRANKLIN JONES

Fellows, our boyhood is going, if it hasn't already gone.

Boyhood has always meant baseball. Remember the nickel rocket and the broomstick bat? And in the big leagues there was only one team for most of us. The New York Giants. Other teams didn't exist. The Red Stockings? Forget 'em. The Athletics? Who're they? The Superbas from Brooklyn? Burns! There was only one team — the Giants. Our heroes. The mighty sluggers from Cogan's Bluff.

A few years back our Giants moved out of the Polo Grounds. After the final game, us kids, 50 years and over, ripped out home plate, grabbed all the balls and bats we could carry, lifted hunks of sod from the center-field pasture and seats from the upper deck, plus old score cards, beer cans and rainchecks — anything to keep a memory of our Giants alive.

MEMORIES . . . we can't forget the first game Willie Mays played. He hit the first pitch out of the ball park.

The Giants moved out of the Polo Grounds, out of New York, to some foreign field called Candlestick Park in San Francisco. It was tough on us Giant fans. But even though they were miles away, we still rooted for them.

But now, word is out they could possibly wind up as the Tokyo Giants in Japan. A deal is in the works for owner Horace Stoneham to sell the team to four Japanese businessmen for \$17 million.

MEMORIES . . . Christy Mathewson being paid a measly hundred bucks a game and winning four World Series games in a row for the Giants.

There's no official talk about the Giants moving to Tokyo. But that's the scuttlebutt among the fans. One of them said yesterday, "What's so crazy about 'em playin' in Tokyo? With them supersonic jets they could be there in three hours, play an afternoon game, and be back for a night game with the Dodgers!"

Memories . . . You had to be there to believe it. In the mid '30s there was a double-header between the Giants and the St. Louis Cardinals. Carl Hubbell pitched the first game against Tex Carlton. You don't have to go to the record book, you've carried the scene in your mind for more than 40 years. Hub, the old "Meal ticket," shut out the Cards for 18 innings and won 1 to 0.

DURING World War II baseball was kept alive for civilian morale. Star players went off to war and guys from the Three-Eye League who couldn't hit the ball out of the infield became sluggers. After the war, the turnstiles' click fell off, and the Brooklyn moved to Chauvis Ravine and the Giants to the Golden Gate.

Should they push on across the Pacific, I can hear new Giant fans arguing about "their" team. Out of the record books they'll pull the fact the Giants won 14 National League pennants . . . they'll read about rough, tough John J. McGraw who came from the Baltimore Orioles at the turn of the century and managed the Giants to 10 of those flags . . . they'll learn of beautiful Bill Terry, first baseman, who was the last National League player to ever hit over 400 . . . they'll hear about how the "most hated Dodger," Leo Durocher, walked into the Polo Grounds one day and announced he was the Giants' new manager . . . they'll be told about stubby Heinie Groh and his stubby bottle-neck bat . . . about Blondie Ryan's famous telegram . . . about Shanty Hogan, Andy Cohen, Travis Jackson, fat Freddie Fitzsimmons . . . and of course Bobby Thompson's electrifying home run into the lower left stands at the Polo Grounds.

If they get them, the Japanese who are ardent, excited baseball fans will have enough to debate about their Giants for another century. Those of us who are left behind — from Montauk to Armonk and from Pawcatuck to Hohokus — will still remember our boyhood with the Giants.